said, “He was judged in court. Why take someone who’s a thief? Why take someone who accepts bribes?”

Rabbis set the agenda for ultra-Orthodox parties, but they rarely do so from beyond the grave. Yosef died in 2013. No one took credit for the leak, but it was believed to have come from Yishai. Deri briefly stepped down, a political stunt that ended when the Shas “council of sages” begged him to return. The party rebounded in the polls after that, focusing its outreach on what it called “the transparent” working-class Israelis who felt ignored in the socioeconomic debate. There was no small irony in this, since Deri is a convicted felon worth about a million dollars.

“People are confused with their options,” Tal Schneider, an Israeli political analyst, predicted before the vote. “Voter turnout is going to be lower than usual because of the general sentiment of disgust.” (It would actually be the highest since 1999, but much of the enthusiasm materialized at the last minute, a dynamic that would serve Netanyahu well.)

“They marginalize our vote”

The sun was setting over Yarka, a Druze village in the northern Galilee, and hundreds of people—local politicians, religious leaders, ordinary residents—were thronged outside a wedding hall to welcome a man most hadn’t even heard of before January.

He was the one fresh face in the 2015 election, Ayman Odeh, a 41-year-old lawyer and activist from Haifa. He had previously been a city councilman and a low-ranking candidate with Hadash, the joint Jewish-Arab communist party. Suddenly, though, he had been catapulted onto the national stage. He had been chosen to head the Joint List, a coalition of the four parties that traditionally represent Israel’s Palestinian minority, which makes up one-fifth of the population.

On the Friday before the election, he was criss-crossing the Galilee. His campaign managers, in an endearing bit of naïveté, scheduled four rallies in four hours. (The Yarka event alone ran for almost three.)

The List was born out of necessity. In 2014 the Knesset passed a “governance bill”, promoted heavily by Lieberman, that raised the electoral threshold from 2 per cent to 3.25 per cent. The Arab parties rarely cleared that line; some, if not all, would have been forced out of government. (In a